SpeechGeek Presents



Female/Female Duos, Vol. 4

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SpeechGeek Presents: F/F Duos, Volume 4

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Three years.

How has it taken us three years to add another volume of female/female duos to our collection? Seriously. The last time we published a female/female duo volume, Jennifer Lawrence was best known for her stint on *The Bill Engvall Show*. Was Angry Birds even a thing back then?

We know that finding materials for two dynamic female performers can be frustrating. That's why we're so fond of this series. Be it dramatic or humorous, there's a special spark that comes from watching two young women take the stage. Though there's been a bit of a hiatus, we're optimistic that we'll be seeing more opportunities for duo ladies to shine.

So pair up your Meryl Streeps with your Anne Hathaways and polish up the pearls. We're excited for you to begin work on these five fabulous new pieces!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Like Falling Leaves

by Stephanie Alderdice

Bold and courageous, KATE dreams of leaving the factory to travel the world and embark on great adventures. Sweet and soft-spoken, SARA is a hopeless romantic at heart who cannot wait to marry and have children of her own.

(*KATE and SARA are working at their respective sewing machines. Despite the fact that they are only fourteen years old, the work is tedious. The room is incredibly hot, and both have grown bored. They begin to sing a made up song as they go through the process of sewing.)*

BOTH. Nip, tuck, nip, tuck, stitch, stitch, stitch;
Pick up a copper piece, save it for a wish;
Pin, trim, pin, trim, snip, snip, snip;
Toss it in the well to get a lover's kiss.

(*Both begin to giggle. They come to a startled halt when their boss angrily reprimands them.)*

KATE. (*looks up)* Sorry, Mister Harris…

SARA. Yes, sorry, sir.

KATE. …We were just humming a little tune to pass the time.

SARA. It really does help to keep the energy up on a long day.

(*Mr. Harris replies that if the days are too long for them, he can find others who are able to keep up.)*

KATE. No! We're perfectly capable of keeping up.

SARA. You don't need to find new girls.

KATE. No more songs, sir.

SARA. Promise.

KATE. Thank you, sir.

SARA. Yes, thank you. (*He exits.*)

KATE. Sheesh. Who put a bee in his britches?

SARA. It seems more like a hive today.

KATE. You're not kidding. I'm sure it must be *so* tiring to have to sit back and watch all of us work. All that looking and leering, I bet he goes home and has to soak his eyeballs in Epsom salts just to give 'em a rest from staring us down all day.

SARA. How disturbing would it be if you walked in the kitchen to get a glass of water and saw two eyeballs floating around in it?

KATE. Eew!

SARA. Yuck! (*They both laugh. SARA's eyes widen as she stops and wipes her brow.*) I really could use something to drink, though.

KATE. What's the matter? Are you feeling okay?

SARA. Oh, yes, I suppose. (*smiles*) I'm just feeling a little worn down.

KATE. You want to go get a drink of water?

SARA. I can't. I've already had one today. If I go back again they'll think I'm slacking off.

KATE. Ridiculous.

SARA. What?

KATE. Not you, the managers, Mister Harris, and the bunch of them all acting like we're no better than dirty criminals.

SARA. Sophia did try to sneak some scraps out.

KATE. One lady goofs up and now the rest of us are treated like rats. It's disgusting having to get patted down at the start and stop of every shift…

SARA. …watching how many breaks we take…

KATE. …and locking all the doors so we can't leave. (*sarcasm*) And why would we want to? I'm having the time of my life sewing garments I'll probably never make enough money to buy.

SARA. (*holding it up to herself)* I think they're lovely.

KATE. Meh. I guess.

SARA. You couldn't see yourself wearing something a little…(*looks her up and down*) less sweat-drenched one day?

KATE. (*laughs*) Har-har, Sara. No, I don't mind the sweat. I like sweat and stink. (*sniffs under armpit)*

SARA. (*giggles)* Charming!

KATE. These clothes are just so boring to me.

SARA. What do you mean?

KATE. Look at 'em. What are you going to do wearing this buttoned down thing with all these frills? Walk around all hoity-toity saying things like, "When I adjourn from the water closet I leave it smelling of roses."

SARA. The true marker of a genteel lady!

KATE. Exactly! That's not for me. I'm telling you, Sara, this world is so much bigger than we can ever imagine. (*KATE's enthusiasm builds as she starts fantasizing.)* There are just so many amazing places and people and things out there to see. One of these days, I'd love to get a boat and go exploring. I would travel down the coastline and see how other people live. I'd visit South America and trek through the jungle. I could discover some native tribe that no one has ever seen before. My picture would be in all the papers, and nobody would stop talking about "Kate the Amazing Girl Explorer!" All the mucky-mucks will pay big money to have a dinner in my honor and hear me tell all of my amazing tales.

SARA. (*playfully teasing her while she's sewing)* But won't you have to wear something buttoned down and frilly when you have dinner with these mucky-mucks? (*holds up the shirt)*

KATE. Nah, they can cram me into one of these ugly old things when I'm dead. (*sews)* So what's your big plan?

SARA. What do you mean?

KATE. What are you going to be doing when I'm off wrestling jaguars and meeting the natives in South America?

SARA. Oh, I dunno. (*SARA blushes, and starts focusing on her sewing.)*

KATE. I know that look!

SARA. What look?

KATE. There's a boy, isn't there?

SARA. I… I don't know what you're talking about.

KATE. Spill it, sister.

SARA. Maybe.

KATE. His name is Maybe? That doesn't sound too Italian to me.

SARA. No, his name is George.

KATE. George, eh?

SARA. He lives a few floors up from my family. I see him in the morning when I leave to come to the factory.

KATE. What's so special about George?

SARA. He's the oldest of five. The rest are all girls. On Sundays, he helps his mother guide them all down the street to go to church. I watch as he carries the littlest girl on his shoulders, the way she rests her chin on his head of thick brown curls. There's a sweetness to the way he takes care of his little sisters and…(*stops herself)* Oh, you'll just laugh at me.

KATE. No, I won't.

SARA. (*reluctant, then caves)* I guess when I watch him take care of his sisters it makes me imagine that he's a father taking care of his own kids. He's incredibly handsome. There are times where I daydream of just falling into his arms and being whisked away from the city. We could have a little farm upstate. On breezy autumn afternoons, we'd watch as the leaves fall to the ground in crackling blankets of red, yellow, and brown. (*pauses)* You probably think I'm boring—what with your dreams of adventures.

KATE. Not at all. That's what a lot of people want.

SARA. I suppose. (*sets down a finished shirt)* Oof, my hands are so sore today for some reason.

KATE. I know how that feels. Don't worry, one day they'll blister up and won't smart so much. (*looks down at her scraps)* If you're done with that one, I can take your scraps down to the bin real fast.

SARA. Thanks, Kate. (*KATE scoops up the scraps and exits. Sara exhales and pulls her hair away from her face and neck.)* Twenty 'til five, almost done for the day and not a moment too soon. (*KATE returns fairly rushed.)*

KATE. Hey, one of the scrap bins at the end of the floor is starting to smoke.

SARA. Really?

KATE. Yeah, it probably won't be anything, but the other girls are talking about getting out until the fire department can put it out. I say we grab our stuff and get out.

SARA. Of course.

(KATE and SARA quickly gather their belongings and head to find an exit. When they approach the exit, the door is locked.)

KATE. Locked. Great.

SARA. (*knocking on door)* Mister Harris?

KATE. Hello?

SARA. There's something wrong with one of the scrap bins.

KATE. It's smoking. Can you please open the door?

SARA. I don't know if he can hear us. (*knocking becomes more urgent)* MISTER HARRIS?

KATE. (*banging furiously)* OPEN THIS UP! THIS ISN"T A JOKE!

SARA. (*waving away the smoke and coughing)* It's starting to get a lot smokier in here.

KATE. (*kicks door)* I don't believe this! They're not unlocking it.

SARA. (*looking around)* Kate, I think everyone is starting to panic.

KATE. Is there anything we can put it out with?

SARA. (*searching)* The managers confiscated all of the water.

KATE. (*searching)* Can you find any metal bins we could put over it?

SARA. Here, let's dump the scraps out of this one.

KATE. Lift! (*KATE and SARA stand by the bin, but are unable to lift it.)* Try again, come on! (*They try again, but as the smoke gets thicker they both begin coughing. The bin drops.)* No!

SARA. How are we going to get out?

KATE. Come with me, there's a fire escape on the other side. (*They dash over to the window where the fire escape is set up.)*

SARA. Help! (*The fire escape is filled with panicking workers. They reach out to get on but keep getting shoved away.)*

KATE. Come on. Let us get on!

SARA. It's no use! There's too many people on there and they won't let us on.

KATE. (*returns to the door, pounding on it)* OPEN THE DOORS! THERE ARE PEOPLE IN HERE! HELP US! PLEASE! PLEASE! OPEN THIS UP!

SARA. (*coughing worsens, she begins to look weak)* Kate, I'm not feeling too good.

KATE. Hold on, Sara. I'll figure something out. (*KATE turns and looks to SARA, then looks to the window. She knows the fall could kill them, but that it is better than the alternative. She puts on brave face to convince SARA.)* The windows.

SARA. What?

KATE. That's our only hope.

SARA. You're not serious.

KATE. Sara, we've tried everything else. They're not opening the doors.

SARA. But the fire escape…

KATE. (*interrupts)* There's three floors of people crammed onto one flimsy fire escape. They're not letting the two of us on there for nothing. Here, look.

SARA. Kate…

KATE. We can pry open this window right here, see?

SARA. I don't know.

KATE. Then we just crawl through and step out onto the ledge.

SARA. (*trembling)* Kate, I don't want to do this.

KATE. Sara, we have to. It's getting real bad in here.

SARA. Maybe if we just wait a few minutes? The firemen could be up here and…

KATE. (*cuts her off*) There's no time, Sara!

SARA. I'm scared.

KATE. (*beat)* So am I, Sara.

SARA. No, you're brave. You're an adventurer.

KATE. Please. You're just as brave.

SARA. No, I'm not.

KATE. But you can be.

SARA. (*crying)* I don't wanna die, Kate!

KATE. Die? Who said anything about dying, Sara? (*pulls up window)* Look, see all those firemen down there? They've got their tarp out to catch you.

SARA. I can't…

KATE. Yes, you can. Pretend George is down there. Pretend that you're jumping into his arms. You'd be just like a leaf falling off a tree branch in autumn, right? All you have to do is just close your eyes and float down to the ground. Then you can walk off into the sunset and have tons of babies with him.

SARA. (*smiles)* Well, maybe not *tons* of babies. Three would be nice.

KATE. (*coughing)* Three is a great number.

SARA. Okay. (*SARA and KATE climb through the window to the ledge.)*

KATE. (*looks at SARA)* On the count of three, ready?

SARA. (*reaches over to grab KATE's hand, smiles)* Ready.

KATE. One, two…(*Holding hands, they look down, take a deep breath, and close their eyes. The scene ends.)*

Dotted Lines

by Sarah Carpenter

SOPHIE is seated in her hospital bed and enthusiastically writing in a journal. KAREN enters and proceeds to erase and update the dry erase board in SOPHIE'S room. SOPHIE is outgoing, charismatic, and witty. KAREN is calm, nurturing, and patient. It's business as usual.

SOPHIE. (*writing in her journal, not looking up*) Hark! Who goes there?

KAREN. (*deadpan, filling out the dry-erase board*) 'Tis I, m'lady, Karen the Pre-Menopausal.

SOPHIE. Oh, Karen, you *slay* me! (*beat)* I said you SLAY me.

KAREN. Sweetie, it wasn't that funny the first time.

SOPHIE. Ouch. Sick burn from Miss Sassy Scrubs.

KAREN. You know I'm just giving you a hard time, Sophie.

SOPHIE. (*leans to read dry erase board*) Ugh, nooo. Charlie is the tech today? He's the worst.

KAREN. (*crossing over to her, chiding)* Sophie…

SOPHIE. (*drawing it out dramatically)* The wooooooorst tech in the wooooorld.

KAREN. I know Charlie isn't your favorite.

SOPHIE. The wooooorst, I'm serious. I've seen serial killers stab more gently than Charlie trying to get a blood sample.

KAREN. (*places stethoscope on her chest)* Take a deep breath.

SOPHIE. (*breathes)* It takes him two or three stabs to get it right. (*mocking voice)* "Sure looks like somebody's veins are hiding today, har-har." My arms end up all black and blue from him messing up.

KAREN. (*checks her pulse)* Go easy on Charlie. He's new and you're intimidating.

SOPHIE. Pffft. If he's scared of a fifteen-year-old girl, he needs help.

KAREN. (*gives her a look)* Really?

SOPHIE. Oh, it's going to be like that today?

KAREN. Have you eaten your lunch yet?

SOPHIE. The porridge covered beef pile with the bowl of lemon-yellow gelatinous cake?

KAREN. That would be it.

SOPHIE. D-E-lightful. Did I detect a hint of cat food in the entrée?

KAREN. (*jotting down notes)* Uh-oh, you'd better not let Joan in the cafeteria find out that you've discovered her secret recipe.

SOPHIE. (*amused)* Karen, you are quite the little scamp today!

KAREN. You're the only teenager I know who uses the term 'scamp.'

SOPHIE. Well, I'm a rare breed 'round these here parts.

KAREN. Yes, another reason why you need to take it easy on Charlie.

SOPHIE. So I like to give folks a hard time, what's wrong with that?

KAREN. Pediatric oncology is a difficult wing to work on, even for seasoned professionals.

SOPHIE. And being the only "not a girl, not yet a woman," scares the poor guy?

KAREN. That and the fact you've spent more years in this unit than half of the staff.

SOPHIE. Behold, the awesome power that comes from having seniority in the kiddie cancer wing!

KAREN. Indeed. (*preparing to leave)* Well, Sophie, if you don't need any thing I'm going to get going.

SOPHIE. Actually, Karen, there is something I need from you.

KAREN. Okay, what do you need, honey?

SOPHIE. It won't take but two seconds of your time.

KAREN. What is it?

SOPHIE. Two things—just two tiny little things. First, watch me do this. (*In a dramatic, "Isn't this simple?" fashion, SOPHIE picks up a pen and signs a sheet of paper.)* Now, all you have to do is sign on this dotted line to say you saw me sign this sheet of paper.

KAREN. (*picks up sheet of paper)* What is it?

SOPHIE. It's wood pulp that has been flattened and bleached.

KAREN. No, smart aleck, what is this form?

SOPHIE. Don't worry about it. I just need you to sign the line where it says *witness.*

KAREN. I'm not signing anything unless I know what it is about.

SOPHIE. Come on, Karen. Enough with the Spanish Inquisition, can you just do me a solid and sign it?

KAREN. Sorry, kiddo. No answers – no ink.

SOPHIE. (*irritated sigh, then intentionally inaudible)* It's an emancipation petition.

KAREN. Louder.

SOPHIE. Argh! It's an emancipation petition.

KAREN. What are you trying to emancipate yourself from?

SOPHIE. (*pause, knows it is about to get intense)* My parents.

KAREN. (*shocked)* What? Why? Did something happen? Have they been hurting you?

SOPHIE. No! It's nothing like that.

KAREN. I've known your parents for years; they're so sweet and kind and funny.

SOPHIE. Tom and Julie are awesomesauce.

KAREN. Then why are you trying to divorce your parents?

SOPHIE. It's complicated.

KAREN. You think? Come on, Sophie, what's going on?

SOPHIE. I don't want to talk about it.

KAREN. Bull. Did you honestly think you could just casually say, "Oh, do me a solid. I want to legally sever ties with my parents. Just sign on the dotted line to make it happen," and I would just go along with it?

SOPHIE. I knew the odds were bad, but I'm a gambler.

KAREN. Good gravy, without your parents the cost of your hospital and chemotherapy bills alone would be staggering.

SOPHIE. *If* I were to get chemotherapy.

KAREN. (*beat, seeing where this is going*) If?

SOPHIE. Maybe I'd continue my chemo, maybe…probably…most likely…I wouldn't.

KAREN. (*gently reassuring her)* Sophie, sweetheart, I know these treatments can be frustrating and depressing, but you can't just throw in the towel.

SOPHIE. I'm not "throwing in the towel." I am loading the towel in one of those t-shirt cannons and shooting the thing out of the stadium. I'm done, Karen. D-O-N-E.

KAREN. Look, cancer is nasty and aggressive in kids and teens. If you can power through it, you've got a better shot in the long run.

SOPHIE. I appreciate what you're trying to do with the whole, "It gets better" thing. You're not telling me anything that my parents haven't already said a thousand times over.

KAREN. Sophie, if you stop receiving treatments now there's a significant chance you won't survive.

SOPHIE. I know the odds are bad, but I'm a gambler.

KAREN. (*dismissive)* Please, you're fifteen. You don't have the experience and insight to make that kind of decision.

SOPHIE. (*insulted)* Excuse me? Did you say that I lack experience and insight?

KAREN. Sophie, calm down, honey.

SOPHIE. (*more aggressive)* Cut it out with the "sweetie, honey," crap. Let me tell you a bit about my experience. You come up here, work your shift, then you get to go home. When you get sick, you pop into the doctor's office for an hour then go home, take some antibiotics, and eat soup. When I come up here, I'm here for days—maybe weeks at a time. When I get sick, it's a life-threatening infection, or a surgery, or medicine that makes my hair and fingernails fall out.

KAREN. Chemo isn't fun for anyone.

SOPHIE. No kidding, Karen. Do you know who else it isn't fun for? The toddlers and little kids that come up here and deal with it also. Do you think I like having to sit across from little kids with big sunken eyes who are screaming and thrashing around while getting their treatments? You want some insight? I don't sleep when I'm up here, Karen. My life is set to the soundtrack of tiny, sick children and grief-stricken parents sobbing at their bedsides. And I'm sup posed to feel like I've won some sort of lottery because I've made it out this long? No. It's a good thing that there's a revolving door at the hospital entrance because even when I leave I know I'm going to turn around and be right back in here.

KAREN. (*struggling to remain calm)* Look, I get it. I know the kids you're talking about. Do you think it's easy for me? To watch the medicine

that is supposed to kill their tumors do its darnedest to kill them in the process? It's horrible. It's not fair that babies, toddlers, or teenagers get cancer. But you don't get to accuse the doctors, nurses, and technicians of not understanding how devastating this can be.

SOPHIE. I am fully aware that doctors understand. In fact, I've read the research. Most doctors have reported that if they were faced with this type of illness, they wouldn't undergo extreme measures. They'd choose to live their remaining days in comfort.

KAREN. What about your parents? I've been there. I've held mothers who were devastated by the deaths of their children. I've seen fathers turn into shells of their former selves. Is that what you want for your parents?

SOPHIE. Don't be absurd. Of course I don't want them to be sad. But I've seen the toll that this has taken on them. If and when I die, they will grieve, but there will also be a sense of relief. No more worrying about the next setback. Everyone else will be at peace.

KAREN. (*increasingly upset)* Well, this just sounds fantastic. If only everyone had it all figured out at the tender age of fifteen.

SOPHIE. Look, Karen, I'm scared. I don't know if I'm going to live long enough to go college or get married or any of that stuff. It's not dying that scares me. It's the idea that my entire life will have been spent in a hospital bed. I've had enough of living in a bubble trying to avoid what's going to happen to all of us at some point. (*beat)* Please. Sign the paper.

KAREN. (*uncomfortable)* What happens if I don't?

SOPHIE. I'll find someone else. Call me sentimental, but I thought it would be nice to see a familiar name on the form.

KAREN. But your parents would be furious.

SOPHIE. So? (*half-heartedly joking)* Aren't all teens supposed to infuriate their parents?

KAREN. Stop it! (*silence, surprised by her forcefulness*) I'm…sorry. (*SOPHIE rolls her eyes.*) I am. I know those words feel hollow to you. You've heard them your entire life. But now you've started to think that's who you are: a sorry, pathetic girl who uses the pity of others to make herself feel strong. I don't believe what you're attempting to do is brave or courageous. It is selfish.

SOPHIE. (*angry and sarcastic)* Yep. "Super selfish cancer kid sitting right here. How dare she want to live her life a little bit?"

KAREN. You don't want to live your life. You want to throw it away.

SOPHIE. You don't know that.

KAREN. I do. I know the treatment plan your doctors have toiled over. I know you have a few more years of struggle ahead of you, but you stand a far better chance of walking out here than most of the other patients. I've held babies who didn't get to live long enough to say their mother's names. I've seen children get brought in with parents

but get carried away without them. I've seen more heartache in my years in this ward than others see in a lifetime.

SOPHIE. So why won't you let me end it?

KAREN. I want you to, but not like this, not by throwing in the towel before you've had a chance to get in the game. You're not terminal; you're tired. I get that. But if you quit your treatments, Sophie, you won't get everything you want. You want to see that whole big world outside this hospital? You want to find love, have adventures, or do something big? You have to keep fighting. It's not fair. But that's life. That's why I'm not signing anything. (*SOPHIE looks away, hurt and angry.*) Listen, I can't say that I know what your life has been like. But until you've had the chance to live it, you don't know what the rest of your life could be like. (*while exiting the room)* I will do anything I can to help you, Sophie, anything, but that.

Mommy and Me Pageant

by Sarah Carpenter

SCENE ONE

(*Begins with mom, TEENA, addressing the camera people/audience.)*

TEENA. (*smiling sweetly)* When I was growing up, my momma always told me, "Now, Teena, there are two types of women in this world: there are the ladies who appreciate the dedication, intelligence, rigor, and poise necessary to compete in pageants; and all the rest are wart-riddled goblins who inherit dark voodoo powers by draining pretty people of their happiness."

P.B. (*screams out)* Mooooooooooom….

TEENA. (*rudely screams back)* PUT A LID ON YOUR YAMMER-HOLE, P.B. I'M MONOLOGUING HERE! (*returns to being overly sweet)* I'm sorry, where was I? Oh, yes, pageant ladies. Dedication, intelli gence, rigor, and poise, or DIRP as we call it, is a cornerstone of pageant lifestyle. You have to really DIRP-out to be successful, and I've met a lot of DIRP-y women through the pageant circuit. We like to joke that the reason our teeth are so white is because we smile so much that eventually the sun just bleaches them out.

P.B. (*slumps into the room)* MOOOOOOMMMMM….heeellllp. I've been trying for the last four hours to get the straw in my juice pouch and…

TEENA. (*grabs pouch, rips open with her teeth, hands back to P.B. while smiling big for the camera/audience)* Here you go, Puddin' Butt!

P.B. Mmm…(*drinks)* Squeezie juice in Rads-berry. Packed with elec trolysis, it's got the stuff kids want and the FDA overlooks!

TEENA. This is my darling daughter. (*begins squeaky baby-talk voice)* I like to call her Puddin' Butt because her teeny widdle bottom is just so sweet and squishy!!

P.B. (*curtsies)* You're welcome.

TEENA. Like I was saying, my mother was wrong about a lot of things. She thought pants were immoral, the people on the tee-vee actually lived inside the set and watched you back, and she greatly overes timated the cleaning power of vinegar.

P.B. Gramma's house smelled like hobbits' feet and salad dressing.

TEENA. It did, bless her heart, but she was right about one thing: pageants. Pageants are a rite of passage for girls to become ladies.

P.B. And for men to become warriors!

TEENA. No, sweetie. That's lacrosse.

P.B. Lacrosse is such a pretty name. (*curtsies)* Bonjour, may-yamo Lacrosse.

TEENA. My Puddin' Butt is very worldly, as I'm sure you can tell. (*P.B. is chewing on her hair, and waves.)* I think the judges in the Little Miss Mommy and Me Pageant will definitely appreciate it.

P.B. Say what, now?

TEENA. Honey, don't chew on your hair. I mean, sure, a woman can carry around a female baby in her womb for nine months, feed, nurture and protect her through infancy into childhood, but is that what makes them mother and daughter?

P.B. (*unsure)* Yes?

TEENA. Of course not! (*P.B. shrugs and begins to pull out and eat chewy candy she had in her pocket.)* It is the shared experience of slathering ourselves in man-made cosmetics, shrouding ourselves in uncomfortable garments, and harnessing our innate competitive spirit to squash the hopes and dreams of any women and children in our path. My mother and I competed, and I'm thrilled to go into (*winks and nudges P.B.)* beauty battle with my lil' Puddin' Butt.

P.B. (*still chewing, holding it up triumph)* May the globs be ever in sour flavor! (*exits)*

TEENA. Exactly.

SCENE TWO

(*TEENA is waiting impatiently and filing her nails. This scene is between the mother and daughter and not directed at the audience.*)

TEENA. For cryin' out loud, P.B. What's taking so flip-flapping long in there? Are you putting on your pageant dress or teaching snakes to arm-wrestle?

P.B. Don't be silly, mom. Snakes like parkour.

TEENA. (*growing angry)* Puddin' Marie Bottom…

P.B. Did you just make up a middle name for my nickname?

TEENA. …if you don't get your sassy, molasses covered, bread-crumb buttered, caboose out here pronto, I'm going to… (*P.B. wobbles out walking awkwardly and struggling to maintain balance. When TEENA sees her, she goes silent and covers her mouth with her hands.)*

P.B. Mom? Are you o-

TEENA. (*Cutting off P.B., TEENA lets out a long, high-pitched ecstatic squeal.)* Eeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeee!!!!! PUDDIN' BUTT! My baby! You look like a princess! NO! An angel! NO! A tiny angel dressed as a princess on Valentine's holding a basket of smiles!

P.B. I can't feel my legs.

TEENA. That's okay, baby girl. Pageant dresses weren't made for the weak. If anyone could wear one, then wouldn't everyone be wearing one?

P.B. Even the boys?

TEENA. Especially the boys. You know the term "fragile ego"?

P.B. Yeah?

TEENA. If your ego is weak, it gets crushed under the weight of the sequins and taffeta. It's true. There's been research by men in white coats with thick glasses.

P.B. Thanks, science.

TEENA. Indeed. That's why Gramma always said it takes a strong woman to compete in pageants.

P.B. I hope you have your glasses on because I'm losing my balance.

TEENA. Only sad people wear glasses, P.B. Here, we'll do some balance-training exercises. This one is called "The Crescent Crown." (*TEENA illustrates the following exercise with precision and grace. P.B. tries to follow along but is shaky and uncoordinated.)* Bend at the hip and gracefully extend your fingertips until they reach the ground. Imagine the Ultra Grand Supreme Little Miss Mommy and Me crown is right at your feet. Keeping your arms completely straight, you lift the crown in a glorious arc and gently place it upon your head. (*Looks over and sees P.B. looking off-kilter. Take a beat.*) Let's move on to hair and make-up.

P.B. I already did.

TEENA. You already did what? Your algebra homework?

P.B. No, my hair and make-up.

TEENA. Were you trying to camouflage yourself as a mouth-breathing, just-rolled-out-of-bed-wallflower for your talent portion?

P.B. I thought we were going for the natural look.

TEENA. Sweetie, there's "Pageant Natural" and "Nature Natural." You look like you've been on a stay-cation at Walden Pond.

P.B. Rude.

TEENA. It's only rude if it is unproductive. This is called constructive criticism. Gramma gave me this exact same brand of tough love when we did the pageant together. Trust me.

P.B. Fine.

TEENA. Now for some teasing…

P.B. When you talk, you look like a pony eating peanut butter.

TEENA. Not that kind of teasing. I'm talking about your hair. (*TEENA pulls out comb and starts to tease PB's hair into a giant pouf. She doesn't react as P.B. cringes.)* Hair needs to have volume like a rock concert!

P.B. Ow! You're pulling my hair so hard I can hear color.

TEENA. You've got to get it big, hon. You know the phrase "Reach for the stars?" In the pageant world we use the old saying "The higher the hair, the closer to heaven." (*TEENA styles it big and sprays a heaping amount of aerosol hairspray. She steps back to admire her work. P.B. is waving her hands and coughing, trying to waft away the clouds of hairspray. P.B. smiles for a moment before her head falls forward.)*

P.B. I don't think my neck can support the weight of my big hair.

TEENA. Don't worry, Puddin' Butt! I saved my neck brace from our (*winks)* fender bender. You can wear for now while I put on your make-up.

P.B. (*beat)* Mom?

TEENA. Yes?

P.B. (*honest and uncertain)* I'm starting to get a funny feeling about this.

TEENA. That's just from inhaling the hairspray, honey. You'll get used to it. Come on. Let's go to the bathroom and see how gorgeous you look in the mirror. (*TEENA and P.B. exit. TEENA guides P.B. with graceful, extended arms. P.B. hobbles along awkwardly, head still hanging from the weight of the hairspray.)*

SCENE THREE

(*In the middle of the pageant. Announcers TRACY and STACY enter enthusiastically.)*

TRACY. It is all glitz and more glamour today at the 25th Annual Little Miss Mommy and Me Pageant, isn't it Stacy?

STACY. It sure is, Tracy!

TRACY. I'll tell you, the love between these mothers and daughters is just filling the room right now.

STACY. It sure is, Tracy!

TRACY. Especially in light of the tragic turn of events that befell the two-time defending champions Martha and Dakota Swanson. Who would have thought that a pair of gerbils could chew their acrylic nails down to their fingertips? Having this night continue in the wake of what was otherwise a spectacular gerbil juggling routine is heartbreaking.

STACY. It sure is, Tracy.

TRACY. Let's continue on with the final performances from our talent portion, shall we Stacy?

STACY. (*pause)* Sure, Tracy.

TRACY. Here is June and Katie Coulson doing their mash-up of the song "Amazing Grace" in the style of top 40 pop princess Ke$ha.

JUNE. (*sings*) Amazing Grace…

KATIE. Grace, getting' up in yo' face, face.

JUNE. How sweet the sound,

KATIE. Sound, boots dancin' on the ground, ground.

JUNE. That saved a wretch like me.

KATIE. (*dancing)* Unh. Unh. Yeah. Grace all up in this place, place.

TRACY. While creative, by the looks of their faces, it may have crossed a line with a few of our judges.

STACY. It sure did.

TRACY. While that performance may have stirred up some drama with the judges' panel, our next contestants decided to STAGE some DRAMA of their own. Here are Paula and Emma bringing on the dramatics.

PAULA. (*stilted, artificial acting)* Thank you for cleaning up the kitchen, Betsy.

EMMA. (*stilted, artificial acting)* You're welcome, Mom.

PAULA. Do you have any plans for the evening, Betsy?

EMMA. I'm going to run a nice warm bath and soak in it, WITH THE TOASTER!

PAULA. But, Betsy, that will surely kill you!

EMMA. That's the point!

PAULA. WHY?

EMMA. Because you are a monster!

PAULA. But I love you!

EMMA. (*pretends to exit)* I can't live like this anymore. Goodnight, Mom.

PAULA. Betsy?

EMMA. *(makes a large ZAP noise)* Ow. I'm dead.

PAULA. (*throws her arms in the air)* NO!

TRACY. Wow. That really touched me.

STACY. It sure did.

TRACY. We have our final contenders for the crown, Teena and P.B. bringing in a little cultural flair with their new wave interpretive dance routine choreographed to "The Sound of Silence in E Minor." Let's watch!

(*P.B. and TEENA emerge with big toothy grins plastered across their faces. They begin to do a choreographed interpretative dance. It is absurd. While TEENA smiles and is the vision of grace, P.B. is having a harder time. She begins to fall out of sync with TEENA.)*

TEENA. (*loudly whispers)* P.B.! What are you doing?

P.B. (*loudly whispers)* I'm trying, but this is really hard.

TEENA. Well trying ain't doing.

P.B. This isn't any fun.

TEENA. Trust me, honey. It doesn't get fun until you get the crown and watch the losers cry. Their tears are lubrication for the soul.

P.B. (*irritated and shouts)* MAYBE I LIKE MY SOUL RUSTY!

TEENA. (*stops in shock, then smiles big and continues the routine, whispering loudly)* Keep dancing, Puddin' Butt. Maybe the judges will think your little outburst is just part of the whole artsy-fartsy thing.

P.B. No, mom. There's something burning deep inside me.

TEENA. That's the hairspray, sweetie.

P.B. No, it's the truth! The truth is that I never wanted to do this.

TEENA. (*in shock)* As Julius Caesar would say, "Et tu, P.B.?"

P.B. Don't try to dazzle me by speaking in Canadian. I mean it. I know you and Gramma bonded by doing pageants, but it's not my thing. This whole Mommy and Me Pageant is supposed to be about mother-daughter bonding, but is anybody really having any fun? We used to have fun just watching television with the sound off and making up dialogue. It wasn't what everyone else was doing, but we enjoyed it. It doesn't make you a bad mom for wanting to do things differently than your mom or the other moms. Maybe looking like a good mom isn't as important as just being a mom. Mom?

TEENA. (*takes a moment to think, then turns to the audience/judges with a big smile)* Surprise! Interpretive dance AND a public service

announcement! I'm sure you'll want to award extra points to such a progressive team.

P.B. MOM!

TEENA. Oh, okay, P.B. I know you're right. I just enjoyed doing these pageants so much with Gramma that I couldn't imagine why you wouldn't want to as well. If you're not having fun, we can just leave. You go out to the car, sweetie. I'll just get my things. (*P.B. turns to leave. TEENA picks up her bag off the floor, then her eye catches something. She slowly and sneakily reaches and starts to put it in her bag.)*

P.B. (*not even looking)* Put down the crown, Mom.

TEENA. Right, gotcha.

SCENE FOUR.

(*P.B. address the camera crew/audience for the final time.)*

P.B. So we didn't win the pageant, obviously. I knew my mom was a little disappointed, but things turned out just fine. In a way, I was glad that I went along with it. That's the hard thing about mothers and daughters. You grow up wanting to be like them, then you fear turning into them. But if you're lucky, you find yourself somewhere in the middle, just wanting to be with them.

TEENA. Hey, Puddin' Butt. I've fired up the pressure washer, if you're ready.

P.B. Mom's going to use the industrial sprayer to help me get all this make-up off. I gotta go now. Thanks again! (*Flashes one last pageant-y smile.)*

Totes Shakespeare

by Paul Owen

Two girls are talking on the phone, not to each other. They should be working on the Shakespeare class project, but have chosen other priorities at present. On one side is LISA., an airhead if ever an airhead existed. Beside her is KIRSTEN, a slightly lesser airhead, but with a sharper, side. They are very into their conversations.

LISA. O! M! G! Are you serious? That is, literally, the worst thing I have ever heard in my life. What a jerkface!

KIRSTEN. That is totes the worst way to breakup ever. He is a freaking moron. What a jerkface.

(*They realize they've copied each other. They laugh and keep going.)*

LISA. No way, we just totally copied each other.

KIRSTEN. We are, like, so close to being sisters it's not even funny!

LISA. (*gasps*) Sisters, that is so sweet.

KIRSTEN. We would be the best sisters ever.

(*They realize that they have left the people hanging on the phone.)*

LISA. Sorry, I got distracted. Yeah? Okay. Yeah. Bye.

KIRSTEN. Okay, see ya. (*She hangs up.*) What a loser.

LISA. I know? How could he do this right before prom? I mean, like, it's a week away and he dumps her for a girl at another school? Really?

KIRSTEN. She's not even that pretty. I totally stalked her on Instagram and she's like a tanning bed girl. Really? You can't go get a real tan, loser?

LISA. Yeah, for reals. It's not like it's that hard to sit in the sun. Duh.

KIRSTEN. That's all the word needs is another "fake bake." Ugh, why are people so ratchet?

LISA. I know, seriously. Well, don't you think we need to start working on this scene? I mean it's due tomorrow and we've not even looked at it.

KIRSTEN. Lisa, you and I both know that we are not going to learn it. What is the point?

LISA. Uh, the point is that it's a big grade. And I need this to be an "A."

KIRSTEN. Fine, whatever. Where's the scene?

(*LISA hands her a copy.)*

LISA. Here. You'll be Rosalind, and I'll be Celia.

KIRSTEN. What the crap is this? Shakespeare's *As You Like It*? Shakespeare, really?

LISA. Well, it was the shortest scene on the list and I figured we'd learn it faster. Look, we can do this, okay?

KIRSTEN. Fine. Let's just get this over with.

LISA. (*as Celia)* Why, cousin! Why, Rosalind! Cupid have mercy! Not a word?

KIRSTEN. (*as Rosalind*) Not one to throw at a dog.

LISA. (*as Celia)* No, thy words are too precious to be cast away upon curs; throw some of them at me; come, lame me with reasons.

KIRSTEN. What?

LISA. That's what it says. "Lame me with reasons."

KIRSTEN This IS lame. (*They both laugh.)* This makes no sense at all.

LISA. Come on. Let's just get through this, okay? I'll keep going.

KIRSTEN (*to herself*) This stinks.

LISA. (*as Celia)* But is all this for your father?

KIRSTEN. (*as Rosalind)* No, some of it is for my child's father.

(They both gasp.)

LISA. She has a child? (*beat*) Whoa.

KIRSTEN. Whoa.

LISA. Can you imagine having a child?

KIRSTEN. Well, if she has a child, where's her husband?

LISA. Wait, this doesn't say anything about her having a child. You're right; this *is* lame. It doesn't even make any sense.

KIRSTEN. (*to herself*) "Some of it is for my child's father." Who could she be talking about, then?

LISA. This says that Rosalind was in love with Orlando. I am totally going to look up Wikipedia and find this out.

(*KIRSTEN's phone rings.)*

KIRSTEN Oh, hang on. This is going to be good. Hello? Yeah? Are you serious? Shut up! No! (*beat*) No! (*another beat*) O.M.G. Yeah, yeah, okay. Let me know. Bye. (*to LISA)* So "Fake Bake" just went to the mall and bought the same dress that I am wearing to the prom. The same freaking dress! Do you think that skank is going to come to my school and wear my dress? I don't think so! Ted is going to have to do something, or I'll never get over this.

LISA. What can Ted do?

KIRSTEN. He can call his stupid friend and tell him that his new self-tan girl bought *my* dress and she has to pick something else to wear. That's what! My life sucks. I'm going to kill her if she thinks she can do this to me.

LISA. Kirsten, she probably had no idea that you had that dress.

KIRSTEN. That is *not* the point, Lisa! The point is that it is *my* school, *my* prom, and *my dress*!

LISA. Wow, okay. Calm down. Seriously. You are yelling at me, and it's not my fault. Come on. We can't fix this tonight. Let's finish the scene, okay?

KIRSTEN. I don't care about the stupid scene right now.

LISA. Yeah, well, I need this grade, okay? So why don't you think about somebody else for five minutes and do this!

KIRSTEN. What?

LISA. You, (*kind of under her breath*) you heard me.

KIRSTEN. Think about somebody else for five minutes? So now you think I'm selfish because this tramp stole my dress?

LISA. You don't know her. And why is it so important anyway? You don't even like Ted anymore, and you hate dancing.

KIRSTEN. That is not the point.

LISA. I know. It's about your dress, your school, and your pride! I know.

KIRSTEN. You know what? Why don't you just do the scene on your own, okay?

LISA. I can't. We have to do it together. Let's just do it. Then you can leave and go worry about your dumb dress.

KIRSTEN. Fine! And you can stay here and wish that you were going with someone better than Frank the nerd.

(*There is a long, awkward pause.)*

LISA. So that's what you think, huh? Fine. I see how it is, then. Well, Ted *is* a better date than most other guys. You would know since you've gone out with every one of them.

KIRSTEN. Oh, shut up! At least I've been out with them! You just sit around reading *Twilight* with your cats like some old lady!

LISA. Yeah, I do. So what? At least I have a life outside of which guy I'm going to be into next. You know, eventually, you're going to run out of guys and have to settle for some old crusty man that can barely see or hear.

KIRSTEN. But at least I'll have a man.

LISA. Yeah, until they get to know you, that is. You know, I think it's not an accident that you're playing Rosalind. She does have a child after all, right?

KIRSTEN. You skank!

LISA. No, that would be you, you butterface!

KIRSTEN. You are such a loser! (*Her phone goes off again.)* Ugh. (*She reads the message.)* It's my mom. She's almost here to get me. Let's just finish this stupid scene, okay? Then, we don't have to ever speak again, okay?

LISA. Fine! Sounds good to me.

(*They start the scene over in a much angrier, aggressive style.)*

LISA. (*as Celia)* Why, cousin! Why, Rosalind! Cupid have freakin' mercy! Huh? Huh? Not a word? Nothing to say, wench?

KIRSTEN. (*as Rosalind)* Not one to throw at a dog... and you know all about dogs, don't you!

LISA. (*as Celia)* Hey, I'm not the pregnant one, am I?

KIRSTEN. I am not pregnant!

(*There is a long pause as they realize how far this has spun out of control.)*

LISA. Rosalind, not you. She's totally preggo. I mean, I think she is. Right?

KIRSTEN. Wait, wait a second. She's not married, but she's in love. Don't you get it? She isn't talking about an actual father, but this guy she's all into has made her so infatuated that she is already referring him as her child's father. She's so in love that the only future father of her children is that guy, Armando.

LISA. I think it's Orlando.

KIRSTEN. Whatever. Lisa? Do you get it? She wants no one but him and she's

so sure that she already has imaginary future babies with him.

LISA. He's her...

KIRSTEN. Soul mate.

LISA. Soul mate.

(*They both gasp.)*

KIRSTEN. Whoa.

LISA. Whoa. Kirsten? I'm sorry for what I said.

KIRSTEN. I'm sorry, too. We can't be mad at each other.

LISA. I don't want to be mad. You are like a sister to me.

KIRSTEN. Awww, Lisa? That is totally what I was going to say.

LISA. It was totes appropes for the moment. Now, let's do this one more time and this time, let's put our style into it. What do you think?

KIRSTEN. I think that you are a genius on so many levels it isn't even funny.

LISA. Okay, here we go.

KIRSTEN. Ready.

LISA. (*as Celia)* Why, like, cousin, like, Rosalind? Cupid totally have mercy! Not a single word?

KIRSTEN. (*as Rosalind)* Not one to, like, throw a little dog.

LISA. (*as Celia)* But is all this for your father?

(*KIRSTEN gets emotional.)*

KIRSTEN. No... some of it... (*tears are about to flow)* is for my child's future father, Othello.

(*They are both sniffling.*)

LISA. (*as Celia*) Orlando.

KIRSTEN. (*as Rosalind)* Whatever.

Generational

by Paul Owen

Katie, a teenage girl, is sitting on her bed. She has been trying to come to terms with the fact that her boyfriend just dumped her—again; to make matters worse, her stepmother is being very difficult on her. Katie's real mother died in a car accident right after she was born. She has always wondered what her mother was like.

(*KATIE'S phone vibrates. She looks at it and sighs.)*

KATIE. No, I don't want to talk about it right now. I'm sure everyone knows we broke up, and I don't care what you have to say. He's a jerk, and that's all you should know. (*She begins texting.)* Just…give…me... space...right...now. Thanks.

(*STEPMOM enters.*)

STEPMOM. Katie, are you going to sit there and feel sorry for yourself, or are you going to help me with the laundry?

KATIE. Mom, I am trying to cope with this situation, okay. He broke up with me and posted a bunch a crap on Facebook, and none of it's true. I can't really think about laundry right now.

STEPMOM. Well, I guess it's okay if you wear the same thing to school tomor row then? I am not doing this for you anymore. I work and have hard days, too. But I have to keep moving. Sometimes actually doing something and not just sitting around will help you feel better.

KATIE. (*She's looking at her phone.)* Yeah, mom, okay, thanks.

(*Her stepmom just stares at her and shrugs in a bit of disbelief that her daughter is just ignoring her.*)

STEPMOM. Fine. We'll see how you feel tomorrow, won't we? You know, I may be your stepmom, but you could treat me with a little more respect.

(*She exits.)*

KATIE. (*to her phone*) Uh, Meagan, why are you asking me that? You know he's full of himself. Look, Mom, I'll come down in a minute, okay? Mom? (*She sighs, leans back and lifts her head all the way back on her shoulders. She mutters in the true teenage emotional style.*) Ugh... why?

(*Her REAL mother enters.)*

MOM. Katie? Hey, how are you doing?

(*Katie looks up and freaks out a bit.)*

KATIE. Who are you? What are you? Wait... Mom?

MOM. Hey, sweetheart. You recognize me?

KATIE. You're... you're my real mom. How...

MOM. It's okay. I'm not really here. I am in your imagination, but it feels real. Doesn't it?

KATIE. Yeah, it does. You look just like the pictures.

MOM. Of course I do. That's the only way you've been able to know me.

KATIE. Man, I wish you were here. My stepmom is so difficult sometimes.

MOM. She's doing the best she can and you aren't making it any easier. She loves you, Kate.

KATIE. Kate?

MOM. Yes, Kate. That's what I was going to call you. If only… well, I'm here now in some way at least.

KATIE. So, why are you showing up now? I could've really benefited from this a long time ago, you know?

MOM. It wasn't time then, but it is now. You need to know some things about the past. I know that your boyfriend broke up with you and that you have been facing some tough decisions. Maybe I could help.

KATIE. How can you help? You aren't even real. And what do you know about my life? You weren't here, remember? Right after I was born, you died in that car crash. What can you do to help me? (*beat)* You know Dad never talked about it to me? Ever.

MOM. That's probably because of why… never mind. I can help you, though. And you should help your stepmom with the clothes for starters.

KATIE. Really? You came back from the dead to tell me to do the laundry? Is the only thing that moms do is force their kids to work?

(*Her great-grandmother appears. She is also deceased and has been for over twenty years.*)

GRAM-GRAM. Well, you kids should work. I don't know when all of that changed!

KATIE. Uh, who are you?

GRAM-GRAM. Who am I? Who are you, little missy? You look like a pathetic little baby sitting there all depressed. Get your butt up and do some work. That'll do the trick.

MOM. Kate, this is my grandmother, your great-grandmother. We called her Gram-Gram.

KATIE. Gram-Gram? Really? So, is my whole family tree going to show up in my room tonight?

GRAM-GRAM. Listen to that sassy little smart aleck child. She needs to good lash on the legs, if you know what I mean.

MOM. Gram-Gram, it's okay. She's not exactly been disciplined too much.

KATIE. What is that supposed to mean?

GRAM-GRAM. It means that you have done whatever you want without any painful consequences. So now you are running around doing Lord knows what with these young fellows. Have you been messing around with the boys, Katherine?

KATIE. Katherine? Really? No, in fact, they seem to want nothing to do with me.

GRAM-GRAM. Well praise the Lord for that. They only want one thing, you know… And it ain't candy neither.

MOM. Gram-Gram, I think she knows what you mean. Look, Kate, the reason we came here is that we think…

GRAM-GRAM. (*She interrupts.)* What do you mean, we *think*? I think. You wouldn't

be here if I hadn't made you.

KATIE. What is she talking about, Mom?

MOM. She means that there's something you need to know.

(*Katie's phone vibrates.)*

KATIE. Wait. Hold on. (*She reads the text and laughs.*)

GRAM-GRAM. What is she doing?

MOM. I have no idea. Kate, what is that?

KATIE. Oh, it's a cell phone. One of my friends texted me. I guess that's before your time, huh? (*They have both left the room.*) Mom? Where did you go? Gram-Gram?

STEPMOM. Are you still sitting here? I really thought you'd at least come downstairs just for the sake of moving around if nothing else. What is wrong with you? Why are you looking at me like that?

KATIE. Does Dad ever talk about my mom? My real mom, I mean.

STEPMOM. Wow, okay, you are really just out to be against me aren't you?

KATIE. I am actually serious. Does he ever talk about her?

STEPMOM. (*A beat.*) No. Actually, he hasn't in a very long time. It's like a chapter that he keeps closed very tightly. I've always wondered why that was. What is the sudden curiosity about your mom? Are you hoping to trade me in for someone else?

KATIE. Of course not. I love you and, look, I'll come and help you, okay?

STEPMOM. Okay, good. I'll be downstairs then. Trust me that work can help. I promise. (*She exits.*)

KATIE. (*She looks at her phone.*) I am leaving you up here, okay? I need a break.

(*Mom and Gram-Gram have re-entered.*)

GRAM-GRAM. Look at that. She even talks to the thing.

KATIE. Oh, okay. So now you just appear and reappear whenever you like?

MOM. Yes, for now.

KATIE. What do you mean "for now"?

GRAM-GRAM. What she means is that we both are about to be gone forever but not before she tells you something very important.

KATIE. What is it?

MOM. I was very depressed after you were born. Not because of you. Just, well, because I was down and had been for a long time. So I started drinking.

KATIE. What?

MOM. And the night of the accident, I had been drinking a lot. (*beat*) The crash was my fault. That's why your dad never mentioned it. He never wanted you to know.

KATIE. You're serious? You were drunk behind the wheel and then died all the while leaving me to grow up without you and never know my mom? And Dad knew? He's been carrying this the whole time? Wow, okay then. Thanks. Thanks for that. (*beat*) But, why are you telling me this now? And how do I know that this is even true?

MOM. Ask him. He'll tell you.

GRAM-GRAM. And, uh, sweetheart? It wasn't just her that messed around with the bottle. So did I. And so did my mom, too.

KATIE. Holy crap. So this is like passed down or something?

GRAM-GRAM. That's the whole point. It can all be different with you.

KATIE. What do you mean?

MOM. What we mean is, that you don't have to do this, too. We know you have, and we know that's why your boyfriend broke up with you. He wanted you to drink with him, didn't he?

KATIE. Yes, actually he did. And I have had some, too. But I don't want to anymore. I told him, and he dumped me.

GRAM-GRAM. He is no good for you. We've all done stupid things to impress someone else. You should also know that your mom would go back and do it all differently if she could. So would I. I'd even pass on the opium if I could.

KATIE. Opium?

GRAM-GRAM. Yes, indeed. Shanghai Sally. Don't ever try it.

KATIE. Uh, okay? I don't think it's been available for about 200 years anyway.

GRAM-GRAM. Well, you laugh, but you better stay away from all that meth and crack and laughing gas and all of it.

KATIE. Look, I get it, okay. I won't do it. It's going to be hard enough to shake off the fact that my dead mother and great-grandmother gave me a "don't do drugs" pep talk in my bedroom, but I'm glad you told me, Mom. I promise I won't do the same thing.

MOM. Good. Kate, I love you. Make us proud, sweetheart. (*They exit.)*

KATIE. (*She realizes they are gone.*) Goodbye.

(*Her phone vibrates again.*)

KATIE. Sorry! I am turning this off. (*She goes downstairs.*) Mom?

STEPMOM. Hey there. Ready to do some laundry?

KATIE. Yeah, I guess so. Listen. I know I've been a jerk sometimes, but I am glad that you're here and that you've been here this whole time. I love you and I want to make you proud.

STEPMOM. (*She sighs.*) You've already made me proud, sweetie. I love you, too. Who were you talking to on the phone up there? Whatever they said must have helped.

KATIE. Yeah, well, they did help, but I care more about what you have to say now.

STEPMOM. Oh, really? Why is that?

KATIE. Because they aren't here. (*beat)* And you are.

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